

AWAKENARTS

Facilitator Orientation & Quick-Reference

A working companion to Appendix A of the Guide

Before You Begin

- Sit with the figure yourself, more than once, before bringing it to anyone else.
- Decide your opening question in advance; keep it observational, not interpretive.
- If facilitating professionally, know your referral resources before you need them.
- Have the Intake / Consent form reviewed before a first session begins.

Opening

- Name the kind of time this will be: no required destination, nothing too small to mention.
- Give real, unhurried silence before any discussion — at least a minute, often longer.
- Ask one open question. Then wait longer than feels natural.

During: The Ladder

Move through these in order — don't skip rungs. Most facilitation problems trace back to reaching for meaning before observation has had room to settle.

1 · Observation	What is literally, visibly there — shape, color, gesture, composition.
2 · Association	What this brings to mind — a memory, another image, a word.
3 · Feeling	What arises in the body or mood while looking — named, not analyzed.
4 · Meaning	What the participant makes of it, in their own words, on their own timeline.

Do	Don't
Default to open questions ("What do you notice?").	Rush to interpret before observation has settled.
Treat resistance as information, not an obstacle.	Push past resistance to get to a 'real' answer.
Let productive silence run its course.	Fill silence because it feels uncomfortable to you.
Stay present through strong emotion.	Rush to soothe strong emotion away.

Watch For

Suicidal ideation or self-harm, current abuse or danger, severe dissociation, or distress that won't resettle. If present: stay calm, name it plainly, and refer rather than attempt to resolve it yourself. See the Guide, Chapter Eleven, and the Intake / Consent form's scope language.

Closing & After

- Brief return to stillness, then one sentence each on where participants are leaving the session.
- Name the ending explicitly — don't let it trail off.
- Afterward, note: figure used, what opened or stayed closed, any signals of resistance or strong feeling, anything to return to.
- Resist “did it work?” Prefer “what have you noticed since?”

Session Formats at a Glance

Individual	45–60 min · one participant · laddered questions at their own pace.
Group	75–90 min · 4–10 participants · round of observations before open discussion.
Return / Same Figure	20–40 min · revisits a figure already encountered, focused on what's different this time.

Full discussion of each of these: the Guide, Chapters Five through Seven, Eleven, and Thirteen; session formats in Appendix B.